

Limitations Statement Template

The Hackles Kit

A free kit by Competence Collective · competencecollective.org · October 2026

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Copy, fill in and keep the matching paragraphs in every report, newsletter, slide, manuscript and administrator summary. The Assessment Pack asks teachers to keep a "limits of these data" paragraph with any shared summary; this template is the research version. Delete a paragraph only if it truly does not apply, and say why.

No student accounts, no student data collected, ever.

01 The short version (for a newsletter, a slide, an administrator summary)

FIELD NOTE	No. 1
These results come from short self-report surveys [and teacher observation] in [N] classes, [without a comparison group / with a delayed-start comparison group]. They show how students' answers [and confidence] changed during the program. They do not show that the program caused those changes, and they do not show changes in real-world behavior or safety. Hackles has not been evaluated in a controlled trial and has not been approved by any agency.	

02 The full version (for a manuscript or report)

Fill in the brackets.

Status of the intervention. Hackles is a free teaching kit. No controlled trial of Hackles exists. Its design draws on prevention science about active, repeated, skill-based teaching, much of which comes from an adjacent field [VERIFY citations]. It has not been reviewed or approved by any state education agency. Nothing in this study changes that status.

Design. [Describe: pre/post, delayed-start comparison, stepped wedge, qualitative, implementation.] [If no comparison group:] Without a comparison group, change may reflect maturation, other lessons, news events, repeated testing or chance. [If a comparison group:] Classes were [randomized / assigned by schedule], so they may differ in ways we did not measure.

Sample. The study included [N] classes in [N] schools and about [N] students per class. Participation was [voluntary for teachers]. Classes and teachers who agreed to take part may differ from others, so results may not generalize. [Small samples give wide intervals; our interval for the main result was X to Y.] We were powered to detect only large effects (about [d]); smaller effects could be present and undetected. [See the sample size tables.]

Measures. The survey items are from the Hackles Assessment Pack. The instruments have no reported reliability or validity evidence. They measure what students know, say they can do and say they would do. They do not measure behavior under real pressure. Students may choose the answer they think the teacher wants (social desirability), especially right after a lesson. Some items were [near the ceiling / had little room to improve].

Data. Student data were provided only as class-level tallies from teachers, not as student records, to protect privacy. This prevents analyses by student characteristics and prevents modeling of student-level clustering beyond the class level. Teachers scored open responses themselves [and a second rater did not review them]. Counts were [checked for completeness / not independently verified].

Time. The post survey took place [N] weeks after the pre survey [and N weeks after the lessons ended]. We cannot say whether any change lasted. [A delayed post survey was / was not collected.]

Causal language. We describe changes in answers, not effects of the program. [If the design supports it: We estimate that, relative to delayed classes, taught-first classes' Tell-Readiness rose by X points (interval Y to Z); this is an estimate from [N] classes under assumptions that may not hold.]

Disclosures and help-seeking. An increase in disclosures after lessons does not mean more harm; a decrease does not mean less harm. We did not use disclosures as an outcome measure, and the research team did not receive any disclosure.

Missing data. [N] students were absent at post or had unusable codes. Results use the students who completed both surveys for matched analyses and all respondents for class percentages.

Multiple tests. We preregistered one primary outcome [registration number]. Other results are secondary or exploratory and should be treated as leads.

Teacher and school effects. Teachers varied in experience and in how closely they followed the lessons [fidelity was / was not measured]. Results may reflect teacher characteristics, not the lessons alone.

Conflicts and independence. [State any link between the authors and Competence Collective or the course, and how it was managed.]

Ethics and law. The study was reviewed by [IRB / determined not human subjects research by the IRB]. Surveys were limited to knowledge, skills and confidence. [Parent notice or consent followed district policy and counsel's advice.] [COUNSEL TO CONFIRM]

Generalizability. The study took place in [setting]. It may not apply to other grade bands, other states, other platforms or other years. The online landscape changes quickly.

03 Phrases to use and avoid

USE	AVOID
"answers changed"	"the program caused"
"students said they would tell a trusted adult"	"students are safer"
"we cannot say whether the change lasted"	"the effects last"
"this study was small and could detect only large effects"	"no effect was found" (for a non-significant result, say "inconclusive")
"Hackles has not been evaluated in a controlled trial"	"evidence-based," "proven," "validated," "approved"

04 Checklist before you publish

- ☐ The limits paragraph is in the abstract or the first page of the report.
- ☐ No claim of effectiveness, approval, certification or prevention.
- ☐ The number of classes and students, and the lack of a comparison group if applicable, are stated.
- ☐ Preregistration cited; deviations listed.
- ☐ No subgroup under 10 is reported.
- ☐ Competence Collective's courtesy review has been offered for factual descriptions of the kit.
- ☐ Conflicts declared.

This template is educational guidance, not legal advice.